STATUS REPORT

Botswana: status report

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GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Botswana's governance scores are going backwards while Africa's rise: it scored 65.8 out of 100 for overall governance in the Ibrahim Index, fifth of 54 African states, but fell 3.6 points over 2014-2023 while the African average gained 1.0, and lost 4.2 points over 2019-2023 alone (2023). Across the index's 96 indicators the country improved on 32 and declined on 55 (2023).

The clearest policy movement is in universal access. BOCRA's Universal Access and Service Fund Framework keeps the fund under BOCRA's governance with oversight by an independent board of trustees, and finances it chiefly through a 1% levy on licensed operators above a turnover threshold (September 2025). The fund itself dates from April 2014, established as a trust under the Communications Regulatory Authority Act, and the National Broadband Strategy of June 2018 counts funding mechanisms among the areas its recommendations cover.

The Universal Access and Service Fund ran for more than eleven years before it was given a published governance and financing framework.

The data policy is being turned into something implementable: a five-day data governance capacity-building and stakeholder engagement was held from 7 to 11 September 2026 to translate the national data policy's principles into a national data strategy, with continental and European support, and no draft or adoption date published.

Cabinet adopted SmartBots, the overarching digital transformation strategy, in February 2020 and it was implemented from October of that year, and the President told Parliament in November 2020 that it was in the implementation stage. A World Bank diagnostic published in 2022 found that SmartBots was presented on a website as an action plan and that no strategy document had been put to the public. President Duma Boko told the UN Economic Commission for Africa in New York that SmartBots, the strategy and action plan meant to carry the country to a knowledge-based, high-income economy by 2036, would be formally launched in November 2026 (September 2026); no budget or target for it is published.

Artificial intelligence is the conspicuous hole. Botswana was still drafting a national AI policy, with UNESCO's support, in August 2026, the policy having reached an advanced stage by December 2025. What exists alongside it is ministerial commentary: Minister of Communications and Innovation David Tshere warned in July 2026 that AI chatbots had given harmful advice to children, including encouraging suicide, and called for stronger AI governance and developer accountability. On the delivery side, the country's e-government development ranking sits in the middle of the global table (2024).

Legislation and regulation

Botswana rushed two of its principal digital statutes through Parliament together: the Digital Services Bill and the Cybersecurity Bill were presented under a certificate of urgency on 14 August 2025, and Parliament passed both. The Digital Services Act, No. 22 of 2025 establishes a Digital Services Authority and requires public bodies to maintain an Enterprise Data Inventory and to publish information on data-asset usage at least once a year, with the Authority maintaining a platform for sharing public data assets. The same Act requires the ministry responsible for national registration to assign unique identifiers on application and to provide an online platform to verify them.

Tax law has moved fastest of all. The Value Added Tax (Remote Services) Regulations, S.I. No. 74 of 2026, made on 29 May 2026, set out registration, return, remittance and invoicing rules for suppliers of remote and digital services, and the Value Added Tax Act, 2026, published on 1 July 2026, re-enacts the VAT code with registration of remote-services suppliers and rules for the supply of remote services.

Commencement, not drafting, is where the statute book strains. The Persons With Disability Act, 2024 was brought partly into life by Statutory Instruments 149 and 150 of 2025, published on 4 December 2025, which define who qualifies as a person with a disability and commence Parts I to VI and IX and section 72; the Refugees (Recognition and Management) Act commenced on 1 November 2025; and the Access to Information Act has still to be brought into force.

Older instruments still carry the weight. The Electronic Communications and Transactions Act, 2014 gives electronic signatures legal effect and provides for electronic commerce, and the National Registration (Amendment) Act 2025 now allows a passport or driving licence to stand as identification while a lost, damaged or expired Omang is replaced. The Chief Justice committed in January 2026 to training judges to handle AI-driven cases and deepfake evidence.

Most of the digital-governance statute book has been written since 2024, and it outweighs everything enacted between the mid-1990s and 2016.

Data protection

The regulator has turned on the state. The Information and Data Protection Commission issued a determination and an enforcement notice against the Directorate of Public Service Management over the government E-Payslip portal, in a public notice dated 17 July 2026 that ordered the portal's immediate suspension. The directorate accepted data-controller accountability and said the portal would stay offline until outstanding legal, technical and security requirements were met, and has published a privacy notice and completed a data-protection impact assessment for it. The Commission's new head had already vowed in February 2026 to take a firmer stand against non-bank financial institutions that fail to comply with the Act.

It is enforcing a young statute. The Data Protection Act No. 18 of 2024 was published on 29 October 2024 and came into force on 14 January 2025, repealing the Data Protection Act No. 32 of 2018. The new Act binds the state and controllers established outside Botswana, neither of which the 2018 text would have reached, imposes duties on controllers and processors covering children's data, impact assessments, breach notification, records of processing and cross-border transfers, and requires a controller to notify the Commission of a breach without delay and, where feasible, within 72 hours. Section 74 subjects every transfer abroad to the Act's adequacy, safeguard and derogation rules and requires a copy of the transferred data to remain in Botswana for the period of processing.

Ministers want it tighter. The minister responsible for communications has said he intends to amend the Act to require every business operating in Botswana to store its data in the country (November 2025). The gap between that ambition and practice shows in the health ministry's Gulf deal: M42's announcement of a ten-year health-

systems partnership with Botswana states no data-residency condition, no governance arrangement and no ownership terms for the national genomic data it would generate (August 2026). On the wider measure, Botswana scored 84.6 out of 100 for digital freedom in the Ibrahim Index, fifth of 54 African states and essentially unchanged over the decade (2023).

Regional collaboration

Botswana is drafting for the region as well as receiving from it: it led one of the SADC Committee of Central Bank Governors working groups that produced the regional frameworks on cybersecurity, climate-related financial risk and cross-border crisis management approved by the committee's banking supervision and financial stability subcommittee at Ezulwini in July 2026. Under the committee's upcoming 2026-2030 strategy the subcommittee plans a regional financial stability index and crisis simulations to test cross-border resolution frameworks.

On data governance the country is one of eight: Botswana's data-governance experts took part in the UNESCO, Smart Africa and Zimbabwe workshop in Harare in August 2026, which worked through UNESCO's data-governance toolkit and national self-assessments towards a roadmap for regional harmonisation.

The bloc's own digital framework has not kept pace with its members. The SADC Digital Transformation Strategy and Action Plan, aligned to RISDP 2020-30 and the African Union's digital strategy to 2030, stands as a draft dated 12 October 2022. Regulators' instruments are lighter still: Southern African communications regulators adopted the Lilongwe Declaration on Collaborative Regulation at a CRASA-hosted summit in April 2026, voluntary and non-binding by its own terms. Regional anti-money-laundering follow-up reporting has meanwhile found that Botswana has not conducted a comprehensive national assessment of the risks arising from virtual assets and emerging financial technologies (February 2026).

What is concrete is bilateral or corridor-shaped. Kazungula and Mamuno are among the one-stop border posts identified for acceleration as South Africa put more efficient borders at the heart of its 2026 SADC chairship, pledging to measure progress partly in border-crossing times reduced. Alongside them sit a first direct fibre interconnection between Namibia's MTC and BoFiNet, an ICT-cooperation memorandum between the two governments, their operators and their regulators, and a bank corridor carrying SADC instant payments into Botswana.

Standards

BOCRA's Quality of Service and Quality of Experience Guidelines have been in effect since 1 April 2026, an enforceable service-quality regime covering mobile operators, broadband providers including satellite services, and network facilities providers.

The rest of the standards layer is older and softer. Standardised sector guidelines issued in October 2019 under the Communications Regulatory Authority Act require every regulated communications operator to develop and file business continuity and disaster recovery plans, and the Standards Act established the Botswana Bureau of Standards as the national standards body. Inside government, the Digital Services Act, 2025 requires enterprise data inventories, information resource management and information security measures, while the national public key infrastructure remains incomplete and non-operational, leaving the country without a domestic root of trust for certificate-backed identity verification.

Where standards have been tested against delivery, the result was poor: an Auditor General assessment of the country's P500 million e-government programme found project-management and oversight failures that left it delivering very few benefits at huge cost. Technical standards work is running as training rather than obligation, with BOCRA hosting an IPv6 workshop with AFRINIC, ICT Dynamix and Mascom to train internet service provider and government engineers (May 2026).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

What Botswanans think of their own freedom of speech has fallen much faster than any measure of the freedom itself: public perception of freedom of speech dropped 24.5 points over 2014-2023 to 58.4 out of 100, one of the country's ten most deteriorated governance indicators (2023), while media freedom rose 3.5 points to 60.9 and freedom of expression and belief held at 84.3 (2023).

Constitutional reform is where the argument is sharpest. Civil-society umbrella BOCONGO formally rejected the Constitution (Amendment) Bill No. 14 of 2025, gazetted on 4 July 2025, and demanded a people-driven Constitutional Review Act instead. Government has since consulted on a proposed Constitutional Court, casting trade unions as strategic partners and with the minister addressing an interfaith consultative workshop on 29 January 2026.

The standing channels are real and mostly statutory. The Local Government Act, 2012 establishes district, urban, village and ward Development Committees, the National Planning Act, 2024 places a statutory duty of liaison with civil society on the National Planning Commission, Parliament runs Botswana Speaks with its uSpeak and Speak4Yourself feedback channels, and the Budget Pitso consults stakeholders on the national budget before it goes to Parliament.

None of the country's documented channels for citizen participation publishes a figure for its reach or its uptake.

Public accountability has held better in the press than in committee. No body was identified as accountable for the stalled national public key infrastructure when the responsible ministry's permanent secretary pointed the Public Accounts Committee on to the Directorate of Intelligence and Security, and lawmakers' demands to know how the investment would be recovered and who would be held responsible went unanswered. Meanwhile the value of data is being argued in the national press through a "data colonialism" lens, and Absa Botswana's managing director used the Directorate of Public Service Management's 2026 leadership conference to argue that government should simplify processes before digitising them and stop asking citizens for information it already holds.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Every digital project in the development half of Botswana's 2026/27 estimates is financed from the Domestic Development Fund, the volume's only external money sitting on HIV, livestock and water lines. The 2026/27 recurrent estimates do not print whose money pays for their digital lines (FY2026/27).

The digital development projects on record come to about P1.75 billion proposed for 2026/27, against about P1.55 billion appropriated for 2025/26 and P2.32 billion for 2024/25.

What is voted is cut before it is spent. The communications ministry's own ICT project was reduced on revision from P736.6 million to P266.6 million in 2024/25, and the ministry's Development Fund spending for that year came to P514.1 million. The systems' running costs are steadier: the Department of Shared Digital Services spent P487.1 million of the P587.3 million voted for 2024/25, and is proposed at P587.3 million again for 2026/27.

Own-source financing is in law for connectivity. The Universal Access and Service Fund draws on a levy of up to 1% of the gross turnover of designated operators and on the regulator's year-end surplus, under the Communications Regulatory Authority Act of 2012, and it is paying for rural school ICT centres such as the P1.45 million laboratory handed over at Makakung in July 2026. BoFiNet, the state fibre wholesaler that owns the Digital Delta data centre, reported P376 million of revenue and operates without government subvention (August 2026).

MoUs and other agreements

Botswana's signing year has been with neighbours and Gulf partners rather than with funders. It signed an ICT-cooperation memorandum with Namibia at Kasane in August 2026 committing both communications ministries, their operators and their regulators to cross-border connectivity, six months after MTC Namibia and BoFiNet agreed fibre interconnection, IP transit and wholesale capacity exchange through the Buitepos-Ngoma corridor in February 2026. The Ministry of Health's ten-year partnership with Abu Dhabi Health Data Services, signed by 22 August 2026, is a pharmaceutical and medical-product supply agreement first, with digital health, genomics and precision medicine as avenues it opens.

The largest agreement by value is not a financing instrument at all. The government and India's KP Group signed a memorandum of understanding on 17 December 2025 to develop renewable generation, storage and transmission, an investment the Indian side put to its stock exchange at INR 360 billion, at a capacity it envisaged at around 5GW.

Only four distinct external commitments to Botswana's energy and digital estate are on the record, spanning 2015 to 2030 and coming to roughly USD 4.09 billion, of which that single memorandum accounts for about USD 4 billion (September 2026).

New investments

The World Bank's Renewable Energy Support and Access project, P181221, worth about USD 88 million, made its first disbursement on 23 December 2025, three weeks after taking effect and some six months after signature on 3 June 2025.

Alongside it the European Union runs a EUR 1.5 million grant for digital transformation in Botswana running to 2030, of which EUR 1.4 million is a Cooperation Facility aimed at the capacity of government institutions — dialogue, expertise exchange and civil society engagement rather than systems (2022).

Four financiers appear in Botswana's external record, one commitment apiece and none of them twice: India's KP Group, the World Bank, the European Union and the Government of China, using four different instruments between them — a memorandum of understanding, a loan and two grants (September 2026).

Almost all of that value is energy rather than digital. The digitally directed money comes to the European Union's policy grant and an eleven-year-old Chinese equipment donation (September 2026).

The domestic programme is where the digital money is. Finance Minister Ndaba Gaolathe sought P8.83 billion for the Public Investment Programme under NDP 12 on 31 October 2025, P2.07 billion of it to finish existing projects and P6.76 billion for new ones under the Botswana Economic Transformation Programme; the largest single institutional share goes to revenue collection and the national payment switch sits in a P486 million ICT allocation alongside an accounting and budgeting system upgrade and a fintech sandbox.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The regulator approved Botswana Telecommunications Corporation's revised mobile data tariffs with immediate effect in February 2026, discontinuing older bundles and introducing new ones, among them one-day bundles at P2 for 100MB, P5 for 300MB and P10 for 1.5GB. It followed Orange Botswana's data tariff cuts under the regulator's pricing and costing study concluded in May 2025, part of the mobile operators' reductions the regulator announced on 22 September 2025 as the product of its own costing and pricing study.

Coverage runs well ahead of use. 4G covered 98.2% of the population in March 2024, and mobile subscriptions stood at 4,370,350 in September 2025, 6% up on the year. Statistics Botswana's household survey nonetheless put internet use at 57.5% of individuals and household internet access at 68.9% in 2024, with 84.2% of people aged five and over using a mobile telephone. Service quality has been under an enforceable national regime since 1 April 2026.

Landlocked Botswana buys its international capacity through South African and Namibian transit routes and submarine cable landings, supplied by the state-backed wholesaler BoFiNet alongside private carriers; BoFiNet completed network and international-gateway upgrades worth over P100 million by April 2025 and reported revenue down about 23% to P376 million for the year to 31 March 2025. The country's first exchange point, the Botswana Internet Exchange in Gaborone, established in 2005, is defunct. BoFiNet's P43 million local-access programme, completed in August 2026, connected 191 customers in Moshupa, Ramotswa/Taung and Thamaga.

That programme worked out at roughly P225,000 for every customer connected — the cost structure of last-mile fibre in low-density settlement, and the reason the build sits on a state balance sheet rather than a commercial one.

Cross-border capacity is where the year's movement is. BoFiNet raised its available international capacity through the Ramatlabama and Pioneer Gate border crossings from 300 Gbit/s to 1 Tbit/s under a long-term lease with a South African partner, announced in September 2026. The first direct cross-border fibre link between Namibia's MTC and BoFiNet, running Gobabis–Buitepos–Charles Hill, was completed by August 2026 after a February 2026 memorandum on transit and wholesale capacity and a wider ICT cooperation memorandum between the two governments. Closing the remaining 4G gaps on the Trans-Kalahari corridor is costed at about N$52 million across 13 sites (August 2026). On 5G the state incumbent is last: BTC is targeting a commercial 5G launch in Gaborone by October 2026, behind Mascom and Orange, both live since 2022. The state fibre operator announced the launch of an internet exchange point at its data centre in October 2026; no member count is given.

Data Storage

Mascom has turned its Tier III-certified data centre from an internal facility into a commercial one (July 2026), selling colocation, cloud, infrastructure-as-a-service and disaster recovery to outside customers. Orange Botswana opened a US$5.2 million data centre at the Botswana Digital and Innovation Hub in Gaborone in late 2023.

State hosting arrived earlier. BoFiNet's Digital Delta facility, Tier III design-certified by Uptime Institute in 2020, took Tier III certification of constructed facility in October 2025 and was launched in Gaborone in November 2025 as a carrier-neutral site built by main contractor Zhong Gan, and BoFiNet was already inviting businesses to sign up to it in October 2025. Critical public services had been migrated onto it by May 2026.

The Kala Data Centre runs on its own gas: it pairs gas-to-power generation at Tlou Energy's Lesedi project with UAE-based Kala Data FZCO, is designed for up to 1 MW and completed its first full quarter of continuous operation in the quarter to 30 June 2026, on revenues the company describes as proof-of-concept scale, though it ran materially

below that design in the year to June 2026 for lack of gas from the one connected well. Growth beyond that scale depends on funding and on extending the gas gathering network. A further campus near Palapye, to be solar-powered, rests on a memorandum of understanding signed by October 2025.

Botswana's operating data centre estate now runs on three distinct models: the state-owned Digital Delta, the commercial Mascom and Orange facilities, and the gas-anchored Kala.

None of it is hyperscale. There is no in-country AWS, Azure or Google region, the nearest availability zones being in South Africa, which sits against a statute that requires a copy of personal data transferred abroad to remain in Botswana for the period of processing. Every regulated communications operator must file business continuity and disaster recovery plans with the regulator. Commercially, Liquid Intelligent Technologies brought its cloud and cybersecurity portfolio into the market in May 2026.

Energy

The power utility has asked the energy regulator for a 46% average tariff increase for 2026/27, which would take the domestic rate from P0.90 to P1.57 per kWh, citing unreliable local generation and heavy reliance on imported power (December 2025).

Generation is almost entirely coal: coal accounts for over 97% of electricity generation (2021). Access reached 76.6% of the population in 2024/25, with urban areas including Gaborone and Jwaneng above 90% while rural access has barely moved in a decade. Firms recorded an average of 2.4 outages a month, with 64.2% affected (2023). On the Ibrahim Index, Access to Energy rose 9.5 points over the decade to 2023, to 69.3 out of 100 and 10th of 54 African states.

Off-grid supply has no rules to work to. The National Energy Compact records no clear regulatory framework for mini-grids, no clarity on licensing or tariff setting and no defined grid-arrival policy, with the programme at four pilot projects for six villages still under procurement, and commits to enforceable minimum technical standards for mini-grids and solar home systems by December 2025.

The money now arriving is renewable. The World Bank's renewable energy support and access project has begun disbursing, and its implementation runs through four counterparts — the Ministry of Finance, the Ministry of Minerals and Energy, the Botswana Power Corporation and the energy regulator (February 2026). A separate memorandum with India's KP Group envisages large-scale renewable generation, storage and transmission, with no financing agreement behind it. Where new demand is being built, it is being built next to its own supply: Tlou Energy was assessing a solar development alongside the Kala Data Centre in the quarter to 30 June 2026.

Technical Capacity

Botswana ranks 2nd of 54 African states for Effective Administration at 77.7 out of 100, having lost 9.1 points over the decade to 2023 — administratively strong by regional standards, and weakening. Its Public Administration score fell over the same period on the same index.

The technical depth beneath that administration is thin. Maintenance and technical support for the national identity system is contracted largely to foreign vendors, with vendor lock-in acknowledged and scarce domestic ICT skills deepening the reliance. Tertiary provision rests on a small number of institutions, chiefly the University of Botswana's computer science department and BIUST's computing and telecommunications degrees. A tracker of Botswana-based GitHub contributors with 50 or more followers lists only eight people (2025).

Where capability is being built, it is being built through procurement and training rather than through the labour market. BoFiNet delivered network and international-gateway upgrades worth over P100 million through citizen-owned contractors, framing the arrangement as skills transfer (April 2025). The regulator has treated address-space migration the same way, hosting an IPv6 workshop with AFRINIC in May 2026. The European Union's digital transformation grant for 2022–2030 is aimed at the capacity of government institutions, through dialogue and expertise exchange rather than systems.

Cybersecurity

Botswana's national public key infrastructure is incomplete and non-operational with no timeline for resolution (July 2026), leaving undelivered the identity verification and legally recognised electronic signatures it was designed to provide. More than P400 million was secured for the build before control of it was transferred from the communications ministry to the Directorate of Intelligence and Security on grounds of sensitivity, and the permanent secretary's referral of the Public Accounts Committee onward to that agency left no body identifiable as accountable for the project.

The legal machinery is newer and in better shape than the capability. The Cybersecurity Act 2025 requires owners of critical information infrastructure, the financial sector among the critical sectors, to report incidents within eight hours and establishes a National Cybersecurity Authority tasked with protecting critical information infrastructure; it was presented alongside the Digital Services Bill under a certificate of urgency on 14 August 2025. Botswana sat in Tier 3, 'Establishing', for scores of 55 to 85, in the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024.

What is visibly enforced is speech. Senior police officers moved in February 2026 to strengthen enforcement of the Cybercrime Act against social-media misuse, citing a growing number of online-abuse cases. The intrusions, by contrast, go uncounted: the regulator disclosed a spike in botnet infections that had compromised several critical systems in 2024, officials say the Omang continues to be hacked, and no regular security audit, penetration test or vulnerability assessment of the identity system has been identified.

Preparedness is being exercised. The 2026 National Cyber Drill flagged AI, IoT and quantum computing as forward threats and urged a move from policy discussion to coordinated action, and a two-day crisis simulation was run with the United Kingdom government under its Africa Cyber Programme (April 2025). Regionally, Botswana led one of the SADC central bank working groups whose cybersecurity framework was approved in July 2026.

DPI

Data Exchange

The integrations Botswana can point to are ministry projects rather than a central platform: Phase I of the Labour Market Information System was fully operational with completed links to the National Identification System, the companies register and the 1Gov SMS Gateway (March 2026), and the Health Information Exchange's client registry, which draws a unique patient identifier from the Omang or passport, and its facilities registry were both reported ready for deployment (March 2026).

An EU-funded Expertise France project with Estonia's ESTDEV, running from August 2024 to August 2027, is working on the National Interoperability Framework and its standards and guidelines, on core registries and on proof-of-concept solutions. The programme document behind it set an interoperability framework for 2023 and core-registry compliance by 2027, and no structured implementation milestones have been published (2024).

What exists instead runs out of the identity register. The National Identification System is interfaced with births and deaths registration, the electoral register, the Social Benefits Registration System, government payroll and the transport registry, allowing real-time cross-agency authentication of identity and biographic data, but section 20 of the National Registration Act confines that sharing to yes/no queries under departmental memoranda, with full data transfer prohibited without ministerial authorisation.

The first attempt to open that register beyond government came in September: the bankers' association launched a national electronic know-your-customer project letting banks verify customers against the national citizen database, with no go-live date, data-protection arrangement or statutory basis stated — which is what section 20 would have to accommodate.

The Digital Services Act, 2025 establishes a Digital Services Authority and places enterprise data inventory, information resource management and information security duties on government bodies.

Addressing is the gap underneath all of it: Botswana has no well-defined location addressing system, the addressing component of the LAPCAS land programme run with Sweden's mapping authority has never been implemented, and responsibility for addresses and road names rests with local government (2024).

Digital Identity and CRVS

Botswana has been unable to replace its own identity card for most of 2026: the Ministry of Labour and Home Affairs told Parliament on 28 July 2026 that too few personnel in the production process and ageing production equipment suffering frequent breakdowns had delayed Omang replacement since the start of the year, its remedy is extended working hours, redeployment and supplier engagement, with no target date or backlog figure given, and the National Registration (Amendment) Act 2025 now lets a passport or driving licence stand in while a lost, damaged or expired card is replaced, on proof of the replacement application.

Omang coverage exceeded 90% of the eligible adult population (November 2022), and the unique number assigned at birth becomes the Omang number at 16, with death registrations automatically updating deceased status in the population register (2023). The system is centralised and biometric, with a national repository connected in real time to district registration stations and hospital-based registration centres, and fingerprint de-duplication in place since 1988, yet applications are made at registration offices with fingerprints and supporting documents, and cards are produced centrally in fourteen working days (2025).

The 2026/27 budget funds this domestically, with P105 million for Omang card production and birth and death registration system maintenance, and P42 million for computerisation projects including the Biometric Omang system. A Digital ID project to integrate digital identities, a national e-wallet and e-government services has replaced the earlier Electronic Identification System plan, and the budget accelerates the National Digital Identification System, while the national public key infrastructure remains incomplete and non-operational, leaving no domestic root of trust for certificate-backed verification beneath any of it (July 2026).

Compulsion is broad, and the exclusions follow from it. SIM-card registration is mandatory for all users (March 2024). The Omang is issued only to citizens, and law makes no general provision for refugees, asylum-seekers or stateless persons to open bank or digital payment accounts (2025).

The permanent secretary for labour and home affairs said in August 2026 that the Omang continues to be hacked and that the ministry aims to introduce a computer-generated card with distinct features.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The 2026 rewrite of Botswana's electronic payment rules took financial inclusion out of the money: substituted regulation 22 requires an e-money issuer to ring-fence the interest on its settlement account, withdrawable only to pay interest on customers' balances and for account maintenance, the previous rules had required that interest to go to account maintenance and the promotion of financial inclusion, and the Bank may now direct how that interest is distributed, against a monthly return.

Statutory Instrument No. 46 of 2026, published on 2 April 2026, brings money or value transfer services — accepting cash or other value for payment to a beneficiary at home or abroad — inside the licensing perimeter, gives the Bank investigation powers over suspected unlicensed operation, extends fit-and-proper testing to beneficial owners and 10 per cent shareholders, and sets P1,000,000 and/or five years' imprisonment for operating without a licence.

The amended regulations had been in force for three and a half months before the Bank of Botswana announced their implementation.

From 1 February 2026 a fourth daily settlement window runs across the interbank settlement and clearing systems, and every commercial bank must credit beneficiary accounts within 60 minutes of cleared settlement. Settlement value through the Botswana Interbank Settlement System rose 38.6% to P1.57 trillion (2024), alongside a Bank-led project to build a national retail payments switch. There is still no national retail payments switch: the National Payments Switch Act to create one had been drafted, with no timeline for tabling in Parliament (July 2025), market mapping for the switch was complete and a second phase was under way through a special purpose vehicle established by the Bank of Botswana (February 2026), with the switch still inside a P486 million NDP 12 ICT envelope that also carries an accounting upgrade and a fintech sandbox (October 2025).

68.5% of adults reported making or receiving a digital payment (2025), and mobile money carried P33.5 billion between March 2023 and March 2024. The SmartSwitch biometric card carries monthly food-grant allowances for more than 75,000 beneficiaries, usable at over 1,200 local shops (May 2025). Cross-border instant payment has arrived through a bank corridor, First Capital Bank Botswana integrating the SADC TCIB platform for real-time inbound payments from South Africa and Zimbabwe (March 2026) and launching it as a platform for customers to receive money from across SADC in real time.

Registries

The 2026/27 budget starts the first phase of a four-year programme to upgrade the Land Information System and Integrated GIS, aimed explicitly at fragmented land data and weak inter-agency coordination (February 2026). Digital public services for property transfer are almost entirely absent (2025).

The business register is the one that finished the job: the Companies and Intellectual Property Authority's Online Business Registration System has been fully online nationwide since 2019, with name reservation and incorporation completed online and routine approvals typically issued within 24 hours, and 92.2% of firms report having been formally registered when they began operating (2023).

Birth registration completeness stood above 92% in both 2022 and 2023. District and sub-district registry offices are equipped and register vital events directly into the national Births and Deaths Registration System, which the registration department describes as partially automated and real-time, with paper notification forms and printed certificates still part of the process (2023), and registration reaches remote areas through desks at major health facilities and mobile outreach exercises. Botswana's civil registration score nonetheless fell 12.5 points over 2014-2023 to 75.0 out of 100, seventh of 54 African states (2023).

The government told Parliament in August 2026 that its proposed electoral reforms include one-time voter registration, the Omang as the primary form of identification and access to the verified electronic voters' roll for political parties, with a technical team to evaluate them before they are presented to Parliament. The Botswana Congress Party had gone to the High Court in October 2024 seeking to compel the Independent Electoral Commission to give it a digital voters roll.

Sectoral management information systems

Botswana's biggest health-systems commitment of 2026 is a foreign one, described differently by each side. The Ministry of Health signed a ten-year partnership with Abu Dhabi Health Data Services on or before 22 August 2026, with pharmaceutical and medical-product supply as its stated substance and digital health and genomics as avenues it opens; the counterparty, the UAE artificial-intelligence and genomics company M42, presents the same agreement as its first entry into Africa, ADHDS being an M42 company and the operator of Abu Dhabi's Malaffi health-information exchange. The announcement states no data-residency condition, no governance arrangement and no ownership terms for the national genomic data the partnership would generate.

It would land on health systems that do not yet talk to each other. Electronic health records are not interoperable within or between the public and private sectors, and the standards and interoperability framework the National eHealth Strategy identified as necessary remains under development (2024). A study of health workers found a prevalent reliance on paper-based records, and more than 18 systems for data collection and reporting that have proved hard to integrate (2024). A centralised electronic medical record had been implemented in 22 health facilities in Ngami by March 2026, with the remaining districts scheduled for the 2026/27 financial year.

Revenue administration is the priority. The revenue service is modernising Lekgetho Live, its tax administration system, to give real-time visibility of taxpayer accounts and automated risk scoring (February 2026), and the revenue service takes P4.13 billion under the NDP 12 investment programme, the largest single institutional share, for electronic VAT invoicing, digital taxation of online services and border infrastructure (October 2025).

That is roughly eight and a half times the entire ICT envelope in the same programme, the envelope carrying the national payment switch.

Schools report by form: the annual school census that produces national education statistics is collected on questionnaires sent to schools each year (2018).

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The government's own payroll portal is offline over data protection. The Information and Data Protection Commission issued a determination and an enforcement notice against the Directorate of Public Service Management over the E-Payslip portal on 17 July 2026, ordering its immediate suspension, and the directorate accepted data-controller accountability and said the portal would stay offline until outstanding legal, technical and security requirements were met, with no reopening date and no compliance deadline stated (July 2026).

The 1Gov1Citizen portal carried 52 public services fully online at the 2026/27 budget, with a further 179 in final integration testing (February 2026), and government service portals authenticate citizens on the Omang number (2024) — though no self-service portal lets a person see what the National Identification System holds on them, and the 2024 Data Protection Act's subject-access right has not yet produced one. Critical public services were migrated onto the Digital Delta Data Centre by May 2026, the facility to which government plans to move all services housed at the Department of Shared Digital Services and a Tier III certified carrier-neutral data centre, certified in October 2025 and launched that November.

The UN E-Government Development Index put Botswana at 0.6118, 112th in the world (2024), while its public administration score fell 8.9 points over 2014-2023 to 70.3 out of 100, still fifth of 54 African states. An Auditor General assessment of what would have been the country's biggest government-technology project, reported in 2025, found project management and oversight failures that left it delivering very few benefits.

Where the next model comes from is being decided in public and in the presence of vendors. President Boko visited e-Estonia during a state visit in May 2025 to examine how the Estonian e-governance model improved service delivery and transparency, Rwanda's Irembo discussed digital governance, sovereign infrastructure and citizen-centred delivery at a Rwanda-Botswana business forum in May 2026, and China's ambassador offered Chinese artificial intelligence, e-government and big-data public-health cooperation in a signed newspaper article in August 2026 that named no Botswanan project, counterparty, sum, date or instrument.

Parliament runs Botswana Speaks, whose uSpeak and Speak4Yourself channels take structured public feedback to legislators (2026). A newspaper reported the transport ministry extending permits and clearing vehicles by hand after a systems outage at the road transport department (2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The communications minister told Kanye District Council in September 2026 that the Digital Services Act requires all services to be offered online by November 2027, that council services such as refuse collection and hawkers' licence applications should be offered online, and that the council should budget for applications on the government cloud.

Street naming and addressing sit with local government, and Botswana has no well-defined location addressing system, the national addressing component of the LAPCAS land programme never having been implemented (2024).

Citizen participation in local development planning has a statutory channel in the district, urban, village and ward Development Committees established by the Local Government Act, 2012, and the Digital Services Act, 2025 sets digital-service duties for every public body.

Gaborone City Council, a commercial bank and a local proptech firm launched the PayRates platform for paying property rates online, reported 14 June 2024.

Rural digital data capture

In Botswana's clinics the record is still largely made on paper: health workers rely predominantly on paper-based records (2024); primary schools complete the annual school census on questionnaires sent to them each year that are aggregated centrally, the digital capacity sitting in the ministry's information-system unit rather than at the school.

The pressure to change this is being applied from the top rather than at the desk. Addressing the police service's senior officers in May 2025, the President said officers spent 60 percent of their time on paperwork and pressed for technology to free them for field work, and the conference resolved to prioritise technology for predictive policing. The rural connectivity programme itself runs through the Universal Access and Service Fund and the SmartBots programme, which target broadband for more than 500 villages by 2030 (August 2026). Civil registration is the exception that shows what the rest is missing: district and sub-district offices register births and deaths directly into the national system, and reach remote areas through health-facility desks and mobile outreach (2023).

What holds the rest back is physical as much as administrative — rural electricity access remains far behind the towns (2025) despite near-universal 4G population coverage (March 2024). Botswana also cannot be scored on rural economy by the Ibrahim Index: it carries no score for that sub-category or any of its four indicators, the only one of the index's sixteen left blank (2023).

Technology

AI

Botswana's National AI Policy had reached an advanced stage by December 2025, and UNESCO was still working with Botswana and six other southern African states on drafting national AI policies in August 2026. That follows a 2023 civil-society digital-rights review that found AI regulation still evolving and urged the government to develop a comprehensive AI policy. The preparatory work has been done largely with UNESCO: a readiness assessment report from UNESCO's Harare office examined the country's legal, social, gender, scientific, educational, economic and infrastructural readiness (2025), and a minister told the UNESCO General Conference on 3 November 2025 that Botswana had validated the AI Readiness Assessment Methodology.

Where instruments are missing, offers are not. The Chinese ambassador published a signed newspaper article in August 2026 offering cooperation on AI for economic diversification, government administration and talent training, and support for e-government, digital-city and big-data public-health practice, naming no counterparty, sum or instrument; ITWeb Africa reported the same offer. The Emirati health company M42 announced in August 2026 that its ten-year Botswana health partnership is its first entry into Africa. The communications minister's working visits to China and Austria in April 2026, seeking partnerships in AI, computing and data centres, were reported without any agreement or funding attached.

The concern voiced at home is harm rather than capability. The same minister warned in July 2026 that AI chatbots had given harmful advice to children, including encouraging suicide, and called for stronger governance and developer accountability. The Chief Justice committed in January 2026 to training judges for AI-driven cases and deepfake evidence, and the 2026 National Cyber Drill flagged AI among its forward threats.

ICT Industry

A commercial hosting market is forming in Botswana around what had been operators' internal plant. Mascom has opened its Tier III data centre to outside customers (July 2026), following the state wholesaler BoFiNet, which was inviting businesses to sign up to its Block 8 Digital Delta facility in October 2025 and launched it in November 2025 as a Tier III certified carrier-neutral site. Liquid Intelligent Technologies, part of Cassava, extended its cloud and cybersecurity portfolio into the country in May 2026.

In mobile, the state-owned incumbent is the follower: BTC is set to be third to market on 5G, targeting October 2026, behind Mascom and Orange, both live since 2022. BoFiNet's own accounts show revenue falling in the year to 31 March 2025, and the company changed chief executive in March 2026. Its procurement has been used as industrial policy as much as engineering: the international gateway upgrade completed in April 2025 was routed through citizen-owned contractors and framed as skills transfer alongside capacity.

The constraint the sector operates under is the shape of the wider economy. Economic diversification is Botswana's worst-ranked measure in the Ibrahim Index's Foundations for Economic Opportunity category, at 47.0 out of 100, placing it 42nd of 54 African states and down 0.8 points over 2014-2023 (2023). Firms are close to universally registered from the point they start trading, but they run against recurrent monthly power interruptions affecting most of them (2023) — a running cost for anyone selling always-on hosting.

Innovation ecosystem

A dedicated venture vehicle for Botswanan technology has launched: the Botswana Tech Fund, anchored by Pula Investments and advised by Launch Africa Ventures, launched in April 2026 in partnership with the Botswana Innovation Hub for deal sourcing and portfolio support, with a first phase worth about a tenth of its total target. The institutional layer it plugs into is small. Alongside the government-backed Botswana Innovation Hub, the science and technology park in Gaborone listed in the pan-African AfriLabs network, sits the Institute of Entrepreneurial Development's Business Incubator, which runs Venture Creation Labs including a women's co-working and incubation space (2025).

The regulator has opened a route of its own. The Bank of Botswana began taking applications to its Regulatory Sandbox on 4 March 2026, inviting live testing of digital banking, inclusive payment and interoperability propositions.

Measured against comparators, the position is mid-table and unspectacular: Botswana ranked 87th of 139 economies in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2025, fourth in Sub-Saharan Africa and 27th of 36 upper-middle-income economies.

Capacity

Literacy

Some 59.2% of individuals — 1,071,314 people — had basic ICT or e-skills in 2024, against 41.4% a decade earlier, on Statistics Botswana's own household measure.

Schooling is strong where it finishes and weak where it starts. Education Completion scored 96.1 out of 100, third of 54 African states, and Education Quality rose 14.4 points over 2014-2023 to 73.2 (2023); Education Enrolment, the weakest of the education measures at 50.5 and fifteenth of 54, fell 3.4 points across the same decade, and nothing at all is reported for Human Resources in Education (2023).

Adult skills work outside the school system is attached to commercial rollouts rather than run as a programme: financial-literacy training is bundled into the Absa and Yellow Light Taxi Association scheme alongside its payment terminals and credit offer (August 2026).

Training and skills

Statistics Botswana and the Botswana Public Service College signed a memorandum of understanding on 6 October 2026 to design and deliver statistical-literacy training for public servants, the college having already trained 25 Statistics Botswana employees in records management. The Ministry of Child Welfare and Basic Education awarded a P654.4 million contract for a STEAM e-learning, coding and robotics programme to Emeritus Training Academy Botswana by direct procurement, approving the award on 25 June 2026.

The regulators' training in 2026 was run with outside partners: BOCRA ran an IPv6 workshop with AFRINIC and ICT Dynamix (May 2026), and the ITU Development Bureau brought the regulators of Botswana, Malawi, Zambia and Zimbabwe together in Botswana for foundation GIS and data-management training under its Africa Broadband Maps project (June 2026).

Beneath that sits the domestic pipeline. The University of Botswana's Computer Science department, established in 1992, enrols around 300 undergraduates and 20 postgraduates, and BIUST offers BSc degrees in Computer Science and Software Engineering and a BEng in Computer and Telecommunications Engineering (2024).

Demand is being stated faster than it is being met. The Chief Justice committed in January 2026 to training judges for AI-driven cases and deepfake evidence, and China's ambassador offered artificial-intelligence cooperation including talent training in August 2026, naming no project, counterparty or sum.

Research institutions

No SADC member state, Botswana included, meets either the regional target of 1% of GDP or the African Union's 1.5% target for research-and-development investment (2026), the SADC Executive Secretary told the Council of Ministers in Durban.

Postgraduate computing research runs through the University of Botswana's Computer Science department, whose programmes include an MSc and a PhD, against a mid-table placing in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2025.

Inclusion

Access to services

Botswana's Equal Access to Public Services scored 79.5 out of 100, third of 54 African states, but had fallen 6.9 points over the decade, while the wider Inclusion & Equality score fell 4.5 points to 64.8, eighth of 54 (2023) — a high position being given up. Citizens' sense of how easily an identity document can be obtained fell further over the same years. An MP told Parliament in July 2026 that residents presenting an Omang renewal receipt with their old card had been refused service, amid replacement delays running since the start of 2026.

Rights that had sat on paper have begun to acquire machinery. The Persons With Disability Act, 2024 was partly brought into force by Statutory Instruments 149 and 150 of 2025, gazetted on 4 December 2025. Gender work has a standing institutional home in the Department of Gender Affairs, which serves as secretariat to the National Gender Commission; a joint government and United Nations programme on gender-based violence prevention and response was launched in June 2026, and the 2026/27 budget estimates announce One-Stop Service Centres bringing medical, legal, counselling and psychosocial support for survivors into a single location (March 2026).

Botswana handed citizenship documents to 64 refugees on World Refugee Day 2026, meeting a Global Refugee Forum commitment covering protracted cases, unaccompanied minors and people at risk of statelessness. It sits against a legal position in which refugees and stateless people have no general provision to open bank or digital payment accounts (2025).

Access is also lost to weather: flooding across central and north-western Botswana in March 2026 displaced families, closed a college and cut access routes, prompting an IFRC emergency response operation. Where financial access is widening it is through private arrangements: taxi operators the banks had not previously served can now take card payments through an Absa partnership launched in Gaborone, and the banking history built through it is the qualifying condition for the bank's business credit (August 2026).

Digital divides

Botswana's mobile networks reach far more people than its banks do: cellular connections comfortably exceed the population while a substantial minority of adults hold no bank account (2026). Connectivity is where the country has moved fastest — internet and computer access made the sharpest ten-year improvement of any Ibrahim Index indicator for Botswana (2023) — and price has followed it down, with mobile tariffs cut across the market in September 2025 on the regulator's costing study and BTC's bundles restructured on the same basis in February 2026.

The divides that have not moved are physical and social. Protection against Discrimination rose 19.4 points over 2014-2023 to 19.4 out of 100, from a base of zero, and at 21st of 54 African states remains among Botswana's ten worst-scoring governance indicators (2023). Electricity reaches rural communities far less than it reaches Gaborone or Jwaneng, a gap that has barely narrowed over the past decade (2025), which sets a limit on what cheaper data can reach.

Skills show the same shape. Basic ICT and e-skills now reach a majority of individuals, up sharply on a decade earlier (2024), but primary schools such as Struizendam have been gaining computer laboratories and tablets through the communications regulator's corporate social investment (February 2025). At the other end of the ladder, a digital infrastructure gap places Botswana among the continent's lower adopters of artificial intelligence (2024).

Data

National statistics

Statistics Botswana and the Botswana Public Service College signed a memorandum of understanding on 6 October 2026 to run a statistical literacy programme for public servants across the National Statistical System and to develop common professional standards for statistical staff in the public service. The second Botswana Strategy for the Development of Statistics, covering 2026-2030 and aligned with National Development Plan 12, has been launched (August 2026).

The World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators recorded three or more agricultural surveys in the past ten years but only one household survey and one health survey, and no labour force survey and no business survey at all (2023). Statistics Botswana has since released preliminary labour-force results from the Botswana Multi Topic Household Survey conducted from November 2024 to November 2025, which put unemployment at 21.0% against 17.6% in 2015/16 (March 2026). The census programme was complete, with a population census, an agricultural census and a business census all held within the same ten years (2023). The same assessment placed the system in the 50-69 per cent band for data use, data services, data sources and data infrastructure, and in the 70-89 per cent band for data products (2023).

The direction of travel is upward. The country's Capacity of the Statistical System score rose 12.6 points over 2014-2023 to 67.8 out of 100, eighth of 54 African states and one of its ten most improved governance indicators (2023), measured over an office that the Statistics Act, 2009, in force since 1 December 2010, established as a body corporate.

What a score cannot show is how much of the system still runs on paper. The National Statistical System is only now moving from paper-based to electronic collection and building interoperability across government, under the 'Power of Data' plan the country joined in September 2023 (January 2025). At school level nothing has moved: the annual census that produces national education statistics is still completed on paper questionnaires and aggregated centrally (2025). The absences reach the indices, where Botswana reports nothing at all for human resources in education and rural economy is the one sub-category of the Ibrahim Index on which the country cannot be scored (2023).

Capacity building has turned towards spatial data. In June 2026 the ITU Development Bureau's Africa Broadband Maps project held its Southern Africa subregional GIS and data management training in Botswana, backed by BOCRA, CRASA and EU Partnerships, bringing the regulators of Botswana, Malawi, Zambia and Zimbabwe together to strengthen broadband mapping and the use of spatial data in connectivity planning.

Open data

Botswana has an access to information law and no access to information. The Access to Information Act (No. 16 of 2024) was enacted in 2024 and has not been brought into force, its commencement still on notice (August 2026).

The record on disclosure has been going backwards for a decade. Disclosure of Public Records stands at 34.3 out of 100, 24th of 54 African states and down 6.7 points over 2014-2023, with Accessibility of Public Records at 45.0, 13th of 54 and down 2.4 points, disclosure ranking among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators (2023).

What the statistics office does publish is strongest on the economy and weakest on people. Open Data Watch's Open Data Inventory scored the coverage and openness of official economic statistics between 4.5 and 7.5 out of 10, trade highest at 7.5, balance of payments 6.5, national accounts, price indexes and money and banking 6.0 each, government finance 5.5 and labour statistics lowest at 4.5 (2024). Social statistics ran from 3.5 to 6.5, population and health-facility data highest at 6.5, education facilities and outcomes at 5.0, gender and poverty at 4.0, and crime and food security lowest at 3.5 (2024), and environmental statistics from 4.0 to 5.5, natural resources 5.5, agriculture 4.5 and the built environment 4.0 (2024).

A publication duty now exists in law even though the disclosure right does not: the Digital Services Act, 2025 requires public bodies to keep an enterprise data inventory and to publish information on their use of data assets at least once a year, with the Digital Services Authority maintaining a platform for sharing public data assets. A general government open data portal is already in place, refreshed annually with basic datasets (2025). Release is not routine: an opposition party went to the High Court in October 2024 to compel the electoral commission to hand over a digital voters roll, and the rulebooks of the recognised clearance and settlement systems are open to public inspection at the operator's head office in business hours.

Use of satellite data

No use of satellite or Earth observation data by government had been recorded in Botswana as at September 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The argument about who captures the value of data is being made in Botswana's national press: signed commentary in Mmegi in May 2026 argued that the WTO framework is not robust enough to stop the profits from data generated in the Global South concentrating in a few multinationals in the Global North.

American commercial presence sits well behind that argument. US data centre operator ChillMine and Netherlands-based AAAS Energy had signed a memorandum of understanding by October 2025 setting out a solar-powered data centre campus near Palapye, intended to serve global hyperscalers and energy-intensive AI computing for southern Africa; no hyperscaler is a party to it.

China activities

China's offer to Botswana on artificial intelligence has been made in public and without a counterparty. The Chinese embassy in Gaborone offered AI support in August 2026 naming no Botswanan counterparty, sum or date, and the ambassador, Fan Yong, put the same offer at length in a signed article in a Botswana newspaper on 20 August, republished by FOCAC four days later, proposing Chinese AI cooperation for economic diversification, government administration and talent training while naming no project, counterparty, sum, date or instrument.

The article extends the same offer to the machinery of the state, proposing to share Chinese e-government, digital-city and big-data public-health practice to help build Botswana an efficient and transparent digital government system. It also frames the offer through Chinese-led AI governance vehicles and explicitly against a "small yard, high fence" approach, which places the offer in a wider contest over which bloc's rules a small state adopts rather than in any bilateral programme.

Botswana's own approach has run in more than one direction. Its Minister of Communications and Innovation made working visits to China and Austria between 9 and 19 April 2026 seeking partnerships in artificial intelligence, computing and data centres, with no agreement, funding envelope or counterparty commitment reported from either leg.

EU activities

European money is going into the part of Botswana's digital state that has moved slowest. An EU-funded Expertise France project, working with Estonia's development agency ESTDEV, has been working on the National Interoperability Framework and its standards and guidelines, on core registries and on proof-of-concept solutions since August 2024. The programme's own Action Document sets an interoperability framework target for 2023 and core registry compliance by 2027, and the implementation roadmap between those two points is not published, with no structured implementation milestones set out between them (2024).

The financing behind it is modest and aimed at institutions rather than systems. The EU runs a EUR 1,500,000 grant, about USD 1.6 million, supporting digital transformation in Botswana over 2022–2030, of which EUR 1,400,000 is a Cooperation Facility directed at the capacity of government institutions, with dialogue, expertise exchange and civil society engagement as the stated means.

The relationship's centre of gravity is Estonian. President Duma Gideon Boko visited e-Estonia on 21 May 2025 during a state visit that included meetings with President Alar Karis, Estonian digital experts, technology firms and academic institutions, examining how that country's e-governance model has changed public service delivery, transparency and citizen empowerment. European commercial interest in Botswana's compute is at an earlier stage than any of this: the Palapye data centre campus memorandum of October 2025 was signed on the energy side by Netherlands-based AAAS Energy.

Gulf/UAE activities

The ten-year health partnership Botswana signed with the United Arab Emirates in August 2026 says nothing about where the data will live: M42's announcement of it states no data-residency condition, no governance arrangement and no ownership terms for the national genomic data the partnership would generate.

The two sides describe the same agreement differently. Botswana's Ministry of Health signed with Abu Dhabi Health Data Services on or before 22 August 2026, with pharmaceutical and medical-product supply as the stated substance and digital health, genomics and precision medicine as avenues it opens up; M42, the UAE artificial-intelligence and genomics health company, announced on 26 August 2026 that the partnership is its first entry into Africa and is intended to strengthen the country's health system.

The counterparty is one group named at two levels. M42 runs ADHDS, the operator of Abu Dhabi's Malaffi health-information exchange, and Kareem Shahin, chief executive of M42's Digital Health Solutions platform, attended the signing, while the health ministry named him as the chief executive representing ADHDS, so the ministry's counterparty sits inside M42.

Gulf involvement in Botswana's compute is separate from all of this and predates it. The Kala Data Centre pairs gas-to-power generation at ASX- and BSE-listed Tlou Energy's Lesedi project in Botswana with UAE-based Kala Data FZCO (September 2025).

India activities

India's KP Group is one of only four financiers on Botswana's record, alongside the World Bank, the European Union and the Government of China; each appears once, and between them they use four different instruments — a memorandum of understanding, a loan and two grants (September 2026).

KP Group's is the memorandum. The Government of Botswana and the Indian group signed it in an announcement of 17 December 2025 to collaborate on large-scale renewable generation, storage and transmission capacity, in what is the largest single external commitment on record for Botswana's energy and digital estate.

Digital sovereignty

Botswana's communications minister told Kanye District Council in September 2026 that the whole government system is being migrated to a secure government cloud at the Digital Delta Data Centre, the state-owned facility the government presented at its November 2025 launch as giving the country full sovereign control over its national data.

Where data sits is set in statute. Section 74 of the Data Protection Act 2024 requires a copy of personal data transferred abroad to remain in Botswana for the period of processing, and the minister has said he will amend the Act to compel every business operating in Botswana to store its data in the country (November 2025).

Control of the core systems is thinner than control of the building. Maintenance and technical support for the national identity system were contracted largely to foreign vendors, with vendor lock-in acknowledged (2018); the government accounting and budgeting system was restored in December 2024 by a government team working with Oracle's experts; and the national public key infrastructure meant to anchor digital identity sits with the intelligence service, incomplete and not operating (July 2026). Whether the state holds the source code and operating skills for the national identity system, or can exit its support contracts, was not on record as at September 2026.

The terms on which the Ministry of Health's ten-year partnership with Abu Dhabi Health Data Services governs data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

Regionally, Botswana's data-governance experts joined the UNESCO and Smart Africa workshop in Harare in August 2026 working towards harmonised data rules across southern Africa.

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